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Decoding leadership in Chinese higher education: a systematic review of insights and innovations (2016–2025)

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ABSTRACT

This systematic review examines leadership styles in Chinese higher education institutions (HEIs), utilizing 24 studies published between 2016 and 2025, filtered from 14,068 articles via PRISMA-compliant selection. Most studies employ quantitative methods, complemented by qualitative and mixed-method approaches. The analysis reveals that leadership in Chinese HEIs is significantly shaped by organizational trust, psychological capital, gratitude, work engagement, and psychological safety. Contextual factors such as organizational culture, guanxi, team dynamics, empowerment, and generational differences emerge as critical moderators. Based on these insights, several key strategies are proposed to enhance leadership effectiveness, including strong communication, constructive feedback, effective remote management, and gender equality promotion. Bridging rural–urban divides, improving crisis management, and integrating advanced technologies are also highlighted as essential future directions. This review not only synthesizes current research but also identifies gaps, offering a roadmap for advancing leadership development in Chinese HEIs.

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1. Introduction

Higher education serves as a critical driver for national development and social progress, especially in China's era of modernization and globalization (Jia et al., 2022). Effective leadership is a core factor for improving teaching quality, research capacity, talent cultivation, and institutional sustainability (Luo et al., 2025; Ahmed et al., 2022). Leadership refers to the knowledge, values, and behaviors enabling individuals to contribute meaningfully and influence others positively (Li et al., 2023). Yet, the Chinese higher education system operates within unique cultural and policy contexts that pose specific challenges for leadership practices (Zhu & Caliskan, 2021).

Recent scholarship has explored diverse leadership styles and their effects on organizational and individual outcomes. Examples include transformational (Li et al., 2023), ethical (Jia et al., 2022), responsible (Luo et al., 2025), supportive (Ahmed et al., 2022), relational (Wang et al., 2022), shared/distributed (Wu & Cormican, 2020), benevolent/paternalistic (Xia et al., 2021), authentic (Sarwar et al., 2022), value-based (Zhao et al., 2024), empowering (Liu, 2022), and negative forms such as bottom-line mentality (Wan et al., 2021) and authoritarian leadership (Cheah et al., 2022). These studies reflect the complexity and diversity of leadership within Chinese HEIs.

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1.1. Problem statement about E-learning

Current leadership practices in Chinese higher education face a series of real-world challenges that hinder institutional effectiveness and sustainable development. First, leadership and development remain insufficient in certain regions and disciplines. For instance, sustainable leadership issues persist in higher education development (e.g. physical education in southern Ningxia) due to limited strategies and resource support (Fu & Zhu, 2022). The transformational leadership competency of graduates in fields like medicine also requires improvement and is affected by multiple factors (Li et al., 2023). Moreover, negative leadership behaviors, such as a “bottom-line mentality” focused on short-term goals, harm teachers’ innovation by undermining psychological safety and increasing feelings of relative deprivation (Wan et al., 2021). Additionally, technology integration, management, and crisis adaptability present major obstacles for university leaders. The adoption of MOOCs and Big Data often faces hurdles due to inconsistent leadership support and employee innovation (Ahmed et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2018). Unexpected events like the COVID-19 pandemic further test leaders’ agility, decision-making, and conflict resolution (Cheah et al., 2022; Zhang & Tian, 2022). These intertwined challenges underscore the urgent need for leaders to balance technological innovation with resilience in crises.

Second, the leadership faced work status, organizational behavior, and performance issues. Academic staff well-being, shaped by teaching engagement and experience, faces enhancement challenges due to complex influencing mechanisms (Pei et al., 2022). Teacher work engagement and innovation are linked to leadership styles, yet not all leadership behaviors are effective (Jia et al., 2022; Liu, 2022; Wan et al., 2021; Zeng & Xu, 2019). Mechanisms for stimulating positive behaviors like organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) remain unclear, necessitating leadership guidance (Luo et al., 2025; Abuowda et al., 2024). Deviant workplace behaviors (e.g. mistreatment, bullying) increase turnover intention and harm the organizational climate (Qi et al., 2022). Insufficient knowledge sharing also hinders knowledge capital accumulation and innovation (Haider et al., 2022; Xia & Yang, 2020). These interconnected issues highlight the need for strategic improvements in both leadership and organizational practices.

Furthermore, leadership encounters gender, ethical, generational, and management model challenges. Women remain underrepresented in leadership positions within higher education institutions (HEIs), as traditional gender norms and leadership stereotypes constrain discourse systems and identity formation (Zhao & Jones, 2017). A lack of ethical leadership can undermine employee ethical behavior and organizational commitment, harming overall institutional health (Guo et al., 2022; Jia et al., 2022; Xia & Yang, 2020; Zeng & Xu, 2019). Additionally, generational differences in work motivation and responses to leadership challenge traditional management models, requiring adaptive strategies to address evolving dynamics (Zhao et al., 2024).

Despite considerable research, there is a lack of comprehensive investigations of factors explaining leadership. A systematic synthesis and integration of these findings is still needed to comprehensively understand the current state, impact mechanisms, and challenges of leadership in Chinese higher education. This review aims to provide a targeted review and analysis of leadership research in Chinese higher education institutions (HEI) development, based on the 24 provided articles, distilling key findings, identifying research gaps, and offering directions for future research and practice. The primary objectives of this review, based on the 24 provided articles, are as follows:

1. To identify and categorize the main leadership styles studied in the context of Chinese higher education.
2. To analyze and summarize the mediating mechanisms revealed in the literature that explain how leadership influences outcomes.
3. To identify and discuss moderating factors that influence leadership effectiveness.

The contributions of this study are three aspects. First, it provides a holistic understanding of the positive and negative impacts of various leadership styles on key organizational and individual outcomes (e.g. innovation performance, teacher well-being, work engagement, OCB, turnover intention, knowledge sharing, technology adoption, team effectiveness, decision quality, ethical behavior). Second, it identifies unique contextual challenges and influencing factors in Chinese higher education leadership, including

policy environment, cultural background, crisis events, technological change, rural–urban disparities, and gender structures. Third, this SLR synthesizes major research methods (quantitative, qualitative, mixed), analytical techniques (SEM, Regression, MGA, Social Network Analysis, Discourse Analysis), and theoretical foundations (e.g. Social Exchange Theory, Social Identity Theory, Social Learning Theory, Relational Leadership Theory). Finally, it highlights research gaps, limitations, and future directions for advancing leadership studies in Chinese higher education.

2. Methods

Systematic literature review (SLR), known for its structured, transparent, and rigorous approach that ensures objective and reproducible results, was adopted in this study. Following the updated PRISMA reporting guidelines (Haddaway et al., 2022; Tranfield et al., 2003), systematic search procedures were conducted to synthesize existing research on leadership. Scopus and WoS were selected for their comprehensive coverage, transparent algorithms, and high-quality academic resources, making them suitable for systematic reviews in social sciences (Gusenbauer & Haddaway, 2020). The final search query was:

TITLE-ABS-KEY (("leadership*" OR "distributive leadership" OR "distributive leadership*" OR "school leadership" OR "principal leadership" OR "student outcomes*" OR "school outcomes*" OR "shared leadership" OR "collaborative leadership" OR "teacher leadership" OR "innovation in teaching*" OR "pedagogical innovation*" OR "educational innovation*") AND (Chinese* OR China* OR high* OR education* OR "universities*" OR "college*" OR "school*")) AND PUBYEAR > 2014 AND PUBYEAR < 2026 AND (LIMIT-TO (PUBSTAGE, "final")) AND (LIMIT-TO (LANGUAGE, "English"))

The keyword 'leadership' was selected for the search string based on the research questions, following PRISMA guidelines. As leadership is a contested term with inconsistent usage in the relevant literature, the authors reviewed numerous articles to identify synonyms, enhancing the search strings. These synonyms were combined using Boolean operators ('OR') and wildcards (e.g. leadership* or *leadership) to retrieve a large number of relevant records and improve recall. The final search query was reviewed by experienced researchers. An information expert developed the search strategy, and the final search query was also reviewed to ensure its quality.

The literature search was conducted on April 24th, 2025, including only peer-reviewed English-language journal articles published between 2014 and 2025, without disciplinary restrictions. Potential reporting bias was minimized by including only peer-reviewed journal articles from Scopus and WoS. To ensure quality and robustness, only papers indexed in the Web of Science (WoS) and Scopus databases were included, following the methodology recommended by Paul and Criado (2020). Other publication types, such as conference proceedings, abstracts, theoretical papers, and book chapters, were excluded to maintain accuracy and impartiality, consistent with Blackhall (2007).

Search results from Scopus were exported as CSV files, while WoS data were manually downloaded. Duplicates were removed using DOI numbers, and the two datasets were merged. To ensure consistency, two researchers independently screened titles and abstracts based on predefined inclusion criteria, excluding non-qualifying articles. The remaining studies were then retrieved in full text for detailed analysis.

This systematic review was not registered in any official registry, and no formal review protocol was prepared prior to conducting the study. The papers within the consideration set were thoroughly screened, excluding those on personal characteristics (e.g. gender, outcomes) as they were outside the study scope. To maintain high inter-rater reliability and minimize bias, authors were randomly assigned articles to assess, achieving 95% agreement, with disputes resolved through team discussions. Full-text articles examining publicly accessible leadership factors were then shared among authors. From these papers, details on research methods, context, unit of analysis, objectives, theories, leadership features, and study limitations were extracted and coded for descriptive analysis. A thematic analysis was conducted to synthesize key findings, systematically categorizing major themes related to leadership styles, mediating and moderating mechanisms, and research gaps. Furthermore, VOSviewer was employed to generate network visualizations of keywords, mapping the intellectual structure of the research field and the interrelationships among core concepts (Figures 1 and 2).

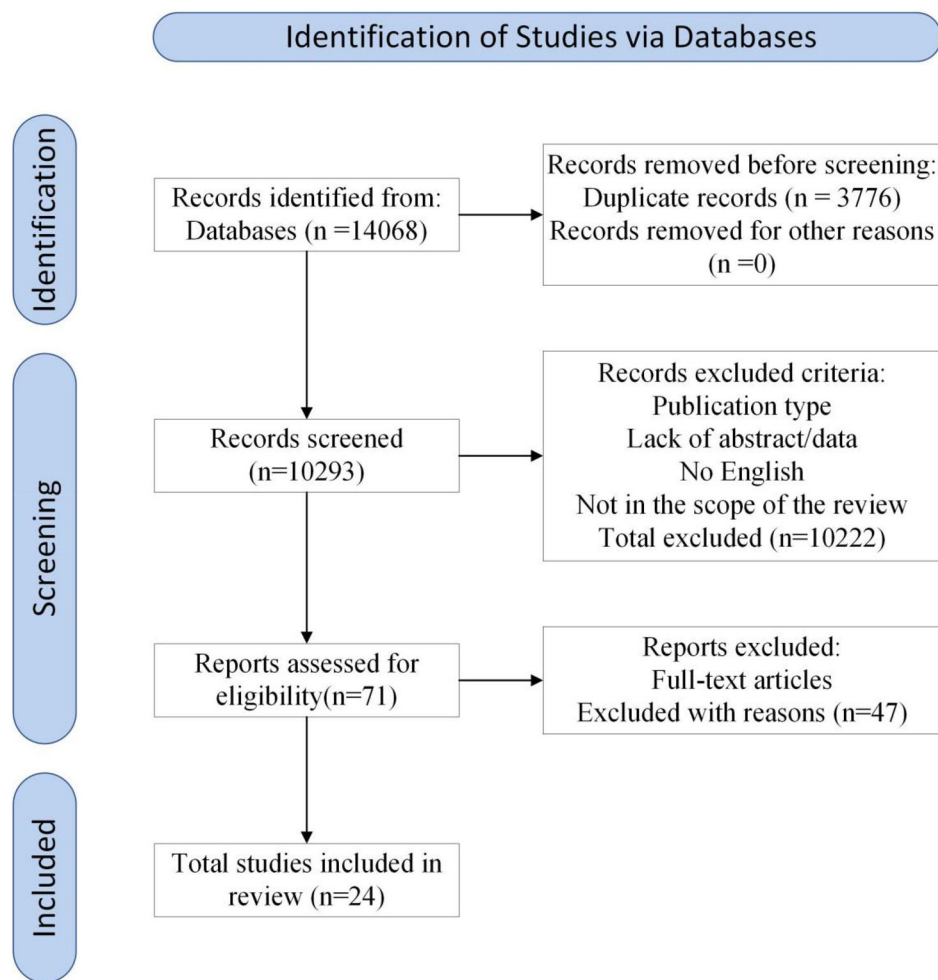


Figure 3. Stages after applying the inclusion and exclusion criteria.
PRISMA flow diagram summarizing the multi-stage screening and selection process of articles for the systematic review.

3.1. Outline of leadership

According to Amrutha and Geetha (2020), the systematic literature review approach frequently offers a thorough source of documentation on various definitions of the idea, use, agreements, and arguments about a topic of interest. Table 1 lists the definitions of all kinds of leadership. The selected literature outlines a series of core issues concerning leadership research in Chinese higher education. Firstly, the leadership and its impact are a central focus. Multiple studies confirm that various positive leadership styles (e.g. transformational, ethical, responsible, supportive, authentic, relational, shared, benevolent, value-based, empowering leadership) can promote employee innovative behavior and performance (Ahmed et al., 2022; Jia et al., 2022; Zhao et al., 2024) and team effectiveness (Wu & Cormican, 2020).

Secondly, the literature highlights leadership in specific contexts. For instance, leader bottom-line mentality (BLM) inhibits teacher innovation (Wan et al., 2021), deviant workplace behaviors (bullying, incivility, etc.) increase turnover intention (Qi et al., 2022), and authoritarian leadership may impair decision quality by exacerbating affective conflict (Cheah et al., 2022). Rural-urban developmental imbalances lead to leadership resource scarcity in rural areas (Fu & Zhu, 2022). Gender inequality restricts women's leadership development and identity (Zhao & Jones, 2017). Crisis events (like COVID-19) challenge leaders' adaptability and decision-making models (Cheah et al., 2022; Zhang & Tian, 2022). Technology adoption (MOOCs, big data) requires effective leadership support (Ahmed et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2018). Generational differences also pose new demands on leadership practices (Zhao et al., 2024). Finally, the studies focus on the mechanisms of mediators (e.g. organizational identification, prosocial motivation, intra-team conflict) and moderators (e.g. organizational culture, guanxi, project life cycle, individual

Table 1. Definitions of leadership.

Author	Keywords	Outline of leadership
Goksoy (2016)	Distributed leadership	It is a leadership approach used since the 1950s, and it is the guide and moderator of educational development.
Jia et al. (2022)	Ethical leadership	Ethical leadership is considered to be driven by values, including the firm belief in the dignity and rights of others instead of personalities or politics.
Ahmed et al. (2022)	Supportive leadership	occurring when leaders express concern for and take account of followers' needs and preferences when making decisions
Wang et al. (2022)	Relational leadership	a social influence process through which emergent coordination (e.g. evolving social order) and change (e.g. new approaches, values, attitudes, behaviors, ideologies) are constructed and produced
Liu (2022)	Empowered leadership	a style where leaders encourage and enable team members to take initiative, make decisions, and accept responsibility
Li et al. (2019)	Transformational leadership	the ability to influence employees' moral values and ethics in such a way that they tend to perform better than expected
Sarwar et al. (2022)	Authentic leadership	Authentic leadership sets a good example in the workplace by demonstrating confidence, hope, and optimism.
Xia et al. (2021)	Ethical leadership	Ethical leadership is characterized by fairness, honesty, openness, values, and trustworthiness.
Zhao et al. (2024)	Value-based leadership	interactions founded on organizational values and ethical standards, emphasizing congruence between organizational, leader, and follower values
Luo et al. (2025)	Responsible leadership	leaders' behavior of addressing stakeholder needs, balancing stakeholder interests, and building trust and reliability with stakeholders
Goksoy (2016)	Shared leadership	a modern leadership approach internalized through voluntary cooperation and interaction based on the competencies of all stakeholders and a sense of responsibility
Xia et al. (2021)	Benevolent leadership	demonstrate concern for their team members' personal or familial welfare

traits). In conclusion, no consensus has been reached on the definition of leadership at this stage, as it remains under development.

3.2. Journal outlets, the field of research and publication year

Table 2 reports the details of the articles. The 24 articles analyzed in this review were published between 2016 and 2025. The research in this area has been particularly concentrated and active in the last five years (18 articles published in 2021–2025), reflecting the state of research on leadership in Chinese higher education in recent years. These publications are distributed across several research areas and journal types, primarily including:

1. Organizational psychology/behavior area: This is the most dominant field, with the majority of articles published in psychology (e.g., *Frontiers in Psychology*, *BMC Psychology*, *PLoS ONE*) and management-related journals. They focus on the impact of leadership on employee attitudes and behaviors. This concentration is considered a reflection of prevailing research trends in the field, not a limitation of the review itself.
2. Educational management/higher education area: Some articles focus on specific educational contexts, such as leadership in physical education, medical education, university crisis management, women's leadership and identity, and technology use in education. These studies are often

Table 2. Details of the articles.

Author	Title	Magazine	Theory	Methodology	Sample
Luo et al. (2025)	The effect of responsible leadership on organizational citizenship behavior: double mediation of gratitude and organizational identification	BMC Psychology	Affective Events Theory (AET), the Social Identity Theory (SIT)	Quantitative questionnaires	317
Zhao et al. (2024)	Triggering Chinese lecturers' intrinsic work motivation by value-based leadership and growth mindset: Generation difference by using multigroup analysis	PLOS ONE	Cognitive Choice Theories; Need Motive-Value;	Quantitative questionnaires	518
Li et al. (2023)	Transformational leadership competency: a cross-sectional study of medical university graduates in China	Annals of Medicine	Social Change Model	Quantitative questionnaires	851
Sarwar et al. (2022)	Authentic leadership, perceived organizational support, and psychological capital: Implications for job performance in the education sector	Frontiers in Psychology	signaling theory	Quantitative questionnaires	350
Guo et al. (2022)	Ethical leadership and workplace behavior in the education sector: The implications of employees' ethical work behavior	Frontiers in Psychology	Social learning theory	Quantitative questionnaires	400
Qi et al. (2022)	The moderating role of transformational leadership on the relationship between deviant workplace behaviors and employee turnover intentions in China	Frontiers in Psychology	social exchange theory, psychological contract theory	Quantitative questionnaires	318
Pei et al. (2022)	An empirical study on the influencing mechanism of Chinese university teachers' wellbeing	Frontiers in Psychology	Selected factors and constructing a model by the author	Quantitative questionnaires	7408
Haider et al. (2022)	The impact of responsible leadership on knowledge sharing behavior through the mediating role of person–	Journal of Innovation & Knowledge	social exchange theory	Quantitative questionnaires	295

(continued)

Table 2. Continued.

Author	Title	Magazine	Theory	Methodology	Sample
Cheah et al. (2022)	organization fit and moderating role of higher educational institute culture Mediating Role of Intra-Team Conflict between Paternalistic Leadership and Decision-Making Quality among China University's CMT during COVID-19	International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health	CMT process model	Quantitative questionnaires	312
Ahmed et al. (2022)	Supportive Leadership and Post-Adoption Use of MOOCs: The Mediating Role of Innovative Work Behavior	Journal of Organizational and End User Computing	information system continuance model	Quantitative questionnaires	712
Fu and Zhu (2022)	Dilemma and countermeasure of sustainable leadership in physical education development in southern rural Ningxia, China	Frontiers in Psychology	five Models of physical education	mixed method	509
Liu (2022)	College Organizational Innovation Performance-Oriented Internal Mechanism Analysis Using Lightweight Deep Learning under Health Psychology	Computational Intelligence and Neuroscience	lightweight DL model	Quantitative questionnaires	340
Zhang and Tian (2022)	The Challenges of Chinese University Leaders During the COVID-19 Pandemic Period: A Case Study Approach	Front. Psychol.	Uncertainty Theory	Qualitative case study	five departments
Jia et al. (2022)	The Linkage between Ethical Leadership, Well-Being, Work Engagement, and Innovative Work Behavior: The Empirical Evidence from the Higher Education Sector of China	International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health	Selected factors and developed conceptual framework by the author	Quantitative questionnaires	370
Wang et al. (2022)	CEO Relational Leadership and Product Innovation Performance: The Roles of TMT Behavior and Characteristics	Frontiers in Psychology	upper echelons theory	Quantitative questionnaires	105
Xia et al. (2021)	Benevolent Leadership and Team Creative Performance: Creative Self-Efficacy and	Frontiers in Psychology	person-environment fit theory	Quantitative questionnaires	251

(continued)

Table 2. Continued.

Author	Title	Magazine	Theory	Methodology	Sample
Wan et al. (2021)	Openness to Experience The Bottom-Line Mentality of Leaders in Education and Training Institutions: Where to Go for Innovation?	Frontiers in Psychology	Social exchange theory	Two-stage Quantitative questionnaires	577 + 503
Wu and Cormican (2020)	Shared Leadership and Team Effectiveness: An Investigation of Whether and When in Engineering Design Teams	Front. Psychol.	Shared Leadership Theory	survey-based design	127
Xia and Yang (2020)	Ethical Leadership and Knowledge Sharing: The Impacts of Prosocial Motivation and Two Facets of Conscientiousness	Frontiers in Psychology	moderated mediation model proposed by the author	Two-stage Quantitative questionnaires	302
Zeng and Xu (2019)	Ethical Leadership and Young University Teachers' Work Engagement: A Moderated Mediation Model	International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health	moderated mediation model	Quantitative questionnaires	205
Li et al. (2019)	Influence of Transformational Leadership on Employees' Innovative Work Behavior in Sustainable Organizations: Test of Mediation and Moderation Processes	Sustainability	social exchange theory	Quantitative questionnaires	281
Wang et al. (2018)	Analysis of Influencing Factors of Big Data Adoption in Chinese Enterprises Using DANP Technique	Sustainability	Motivation Opportunity Ability Model	questionnaire	20
Zhao and Jones (2017)	Women and Leadership in Higher Education in China: Discourse and the Discursive Construction of Identity	Administrative Sciences	Theories of Discourse acknowledge	in-depth qualitative interviews	9
Goksoy (2016)	Analysis of the Relationship between Shared Leadership and Distributed Leadership	Eurasian Journal of Educational Research	relational survey model	Quantitative questionnaires	402

published in education or interdisciplinary journals (e.g., Educational Psychology sections of Frontiers in Psychology, Administrative Sciences, Eurasian Journal of Educational Research).

3. Leadership studies area: Literature directly discusses leadership theory itself and its application, such as relational leadership and shared/distributed leadership.

4. Technology adoption and management area: Research involving MOOC adoption and big data adoption is typically published in journals related to information systems, technology management, or sustainability (e.g., *Journal of Organizational and End User Computing*, *Sustainability*).
5. Interdisciplinary Research: Studies integrate perspectives from multiple fields, including psychology, management, education, sociology (e.g., gender studies), and technology science.

3.3. Paper types and methods applied

All 24 articles analyzed in this systematic review are original empirical studies on leadership in Chinese higher education. As shown in Table 2, 22 employed quantitative methods, primarily questionnaire surveys using Likert scales. Some adopted multi-source or multi-stage data collection to reduce common method bias. Common statistical techniques included correlation analysis, reliability and validity tests (e.g. Cronbach's Alpha, AVE, CR, HTMT), and factor analysis. Major analytical approach is the Structural Equation Modeling (SEM), Encompassing both covariance-based SEM (CB-SEM) and partial least squares SEM (PLS-SEM), employed to test complex path relationships, mediation, and moderation effects. Multi-group analysis (MGA) was also used to compare path differences across groups (e.g. generational cohorts). Regression analysis, including hierarchical and bootstrapping methods, further examined direct, mediating, and moderating effects. Other approaches, such as PROCESS Macro, Social Network Analysis (SNA), and DANP (DEMATEL-based ANP), were applied to explore leadership network density and moderated mediation models. However, reliance on closed-ended questionnaires may overlook valuable insights obtainable through qualitative interviews or focus groups (Alaei et al., 2019; Nigel, 2023).

The rest of the studies are qualitative research and mixed methods research. Qualitative research is relatively less common but provides an in-depth understanding. This study employed in-depth interviews (Zhao & Jones, 2017) and case studies (Zhang & Tian, 2022) to gather contextualized data. Discourse and thematic analyses were used to identify patterns and themes in the data, enhancing the interpretive rigor of the research. Fu and Zhu (2022) explicitly adopted a mixed and multi-method approach, combining qualitative interviews, cross-sectional data collection, and case studies.

Overall, quantitative research, particularly based on questionnaire surveys and SEM/PLS-SEM analysis, represents the mainstream methodology in this field, aiming to test relationships between variables and model generalizability. Qualitative research offers a deep contextual understanding of specific phenomena (like gender identity or crisis management challenges). The use of mixed methods is not yet widespread but shows potential for integrating the strengths of different approaches (harvard.edu, 2018).

3.4. Research context and unit of analysis

Many previous studies on leadership have focused on various organizational settings globally. However, all articles included in this systematic review specifically investigated leadership within the context of Chinese higher education institutions (universities) (e.g. Jia et al., 2022; Li et al., 2023; Luo et al., 2025; Pei et al., 2022; Xia et al., 2021; Zeng & Xu, 2019). All types of leadership are described in Figure 4. The reviewed literature addressed a spectrum of leadership styles, including transformational, ethical, responsible, authentic, value-based, supportive, benevolent, paternalistic, shared, and distributed leadership. The primary objective across these studies was typically to examine the impact of these leadership styles on a range of employee and team outcomes, such as well-being, work engagement, innovative work behavior, organizational citizenship behavior, job performance, trust in leader, organizational identification, knowledge sharing behavior, and decision-making quality. Mediating and moderating variables like psychological capital, organizational commitment, organizational culture, and personality traits (e.g. Luo et al., 2025; Pei et al., 2022; Zhao et al., 2024) were also frequently explored to understand the underlying mechanisms and boundary conditions.

Of the analyzed studies, most used academic staff (teachers, lecturers, or faculty members) as the primary unit of analysis, examining their perceptions of leadership and related attitudes and behaviors (e.g. Jia et al., 2022; Luo et al., 2025; Pei et al., 2022; Sarwar et al., 2022; Zeng & Xu, 2019; Zhao et al., 2024). A smaller number focused on Top Management Teams (TMTs) or leaders themselves (Cheah et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2022; Zhang & Tian, 2022). Focusing on academic staff offers valuable insights into how

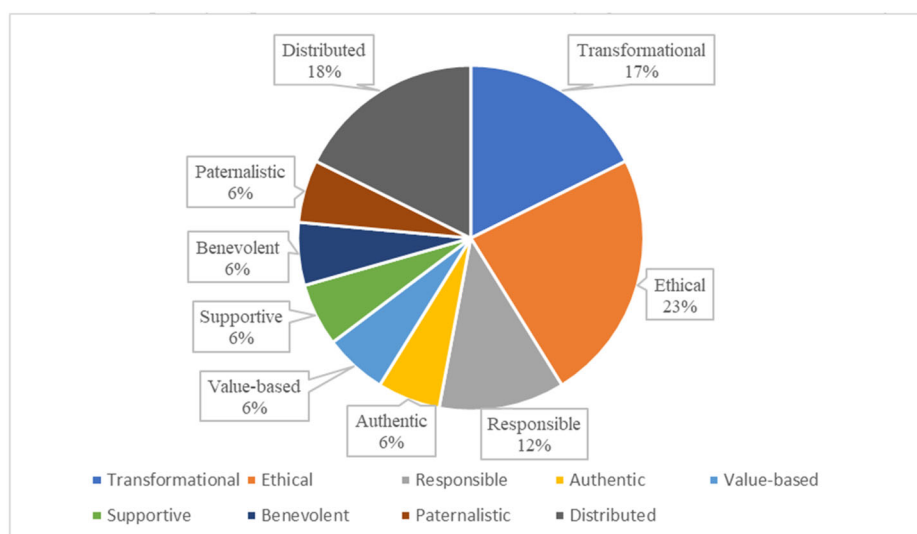


Figure 4. Types of leadership.

Shows all leadership types in the review, including transformational, ethical, responsible, authentic, value-based, supportive, and distributed.

leadership affects core teaching and research activities but may overlook broader institutional dynamics or student outcomes. Conversely, studying leaders provides direct behavioral data yet may miss follower perceptions that shape responses. Hence, relying solely on one group limits understanding. Future studies could adopt multi-level or multi-source designs—such as leader-follower dyads, team-level analyses, or inclusion of student outcomes—to develop a more comprehensive view.

There was a clear dominance of the Chinese higher education context in the reviewed literature set for this specific review. While leadership theories are often developed globally, their applicability and manifestation can be context-dependent. The reviewed studies implicitly or explicitly operate within the unique cultural and institutional environment of Chinese universities, which may involve specific power dynamics, communication styles, and value orientations (e.g. influenced by Confucian traditions or specific institutional policies) not always comparable to Western contexts where many leadership theories originated (Cheah et al., 2022; Zhao et al., 2024). This focused context allows for depth but limits immediate cross-cultural generalizability. Future studies could address this limitation by conducting comparative research across different national cultures or contrasting leadership effectiveness between different types of educational institutions within or outside China (e.g. public vs. private, different tiers like “985/211 Universities” vs. others).

3.5. Theoretical foundations: Integrating western theories in a Chinese context

The 24 selected articles utilize various theoretical frameworks to explain leadership phenomena and their impacts within the Chinese higher education context. Their theoretical foundations are listed in Table 3. An overview and comparison of the main theoretical foundations are three ways:

The first is about the foundational social interaction theories. Among the theoretical frameworks employed in the selected studies, Social Exchange Theory (SET) stands out as one of the most fundamental and widely applied. It underpins the analysis in numerous articles, explaining the reciprocal dynamics between various leadership styles (including ethical, responsible, supportive, relational, benevolent, transformational, authentic, and even bottom-line mentality) and a wide array of employee attitudes and behaviors such as organizational commitment, trust, OCB, work engagement, knowledge sharing, innovative behavior, turnover intention, and ethical conduct. The core tenet applied is that employees reciprocate perceived positive or negative treatment from leaders and the organization with corresponding positive or negative behaviors. 11 articles used the SET to explain the leadership and its influence. Complementing this, social learning theory (SLT) is frequently invoked, particularly for ethical (Jia et al., 2022) and authentic leadership styles (Sarwar et al., 2022). SLT emphasizes the role of

Table 3. Theoretical frameworks distribution.

Theoretical foundations	Number of articles
Social Exchange Theory	11
Social Learning Theory	3
Social Identity Theory	2
Affective Events Theory	2
Expectation-Confirmation Theory / IS Continuance Model	1
Upper Echelons Theory	1
Relational Leadership Theory	1
Uncertainty Theory (Zhang & Tian, 2022)	1
Self-Determination Theory	1
Motivation Opportunity Ability Model	1
Signaling Theory	1

observational learning and role modeling, suggesting that employees learn and internalize norms, values, and ethical standards by observing and imitating their leaders' actions, thereby shaping their own workplace behaviors.

The second category involves theories explaining psychological mechanisms linking leadership to employee outcomes. Social Identity Theory (SIT) posits that leadership (e.g. responsible leadership) promotes pro-organizational behaviors such as OCB and knowledge sharing by strengthening employees' organizational identification—where the organization becomes part of their self-concept (Luo et al., 2025; Haider et al., 2022). Positive leader actions enhance organizational prestige, deepening identification and motivating group-oriented behaviors. Affective Events Theory (AET) emphasizes emotions, suggesting leadership behaviors trigger emotional responses (e.g. gratitude) that shape attitudes and behaviors like OCB, complementing cognitive perspectives such as SET (Haider et al., 2022). Self-Determination Theory (SDT) explains intrinsic motivation, arguing that leadership styles (e.g. value-based) and mindsets (e.g. growth mindset) enhance motivation by fulfilling autonomy and competence needs (Zhao et al., 2024). Finally, Signaling Theory explains how authentic leaders convey cues about morality and integrity under information asymmetry, influencing employees' psychological capital and performance (Sarwar et al., 2022).

The third group comprises context-specific and organizational-level theories. Upper Echelons Theory (UET) provides a strategic lens, explaining how top executives' characteristics and leadership styles (e.g. relational leadership) affect organizational outcomes like innovation, often mediated by TMT dynamics and moderated by team characteristics (Wang et al., 2022). Relational Leadership Theory emphasizes leadership as a social process built through interaction and shared meaning, as shown in studies linking CEO relational leadership to innovation. The Motivation–Opportunity–Ability (MOA) model integrates internal factors (motivation, ability) with external conditions to explain technology adoption, such as Big Data (Wang et al., 2018). Expectation Confirmation Theory (ECT) and the Information Systems Continuance (ISC) model address post-adoption behavior (e.g. MOOCs), linking continuance intention to satisfaction and perceived usefulness (Ahmed et al., 2022). Finally, Uncertainty Theory examines leadership decision-making under crisis conditions, such as university leaders' responses during COVID-19 (Zhang & Tian, 2022).

A deeper theoretical synthesis reveals both resonance and divergence when applying these predominantly Western-derived theories to the Chinese context. For instance, the principle of reciprocity in Social Exchange Theory (SET) resonates strongly with the Confucian value of *guanxi*, where reciprocal obligations and interpersonal harmony are central. However, the formal, transactional nature often assumed in Western applications of SET is complicated by the deeply embedded, long-term, and multifaceted nature of *guanxi*. Similarly, theories like Self-Determination Theory (SDT), which emphasize autonomy, must be contextualized within China's unique institutional duality, such as the "Party committee leadership and president responsibility system". This dual governance structure introduces a layer of collective oversight and political consideration that reshapes the expression and pursuit of individual autonomy, presenting a conceptual challenge not typically addressed in Western leadership models. Integrating these cultural and institutional nuances is crucial for a more profound understanding of leadership dynamics in Chinese HEIs.

Table 4. Leadership reviewed key factors.

No	Factors	Outline of leadership	Authors
1	Transformational leadership	Competency; Innovation; Trust & Empowerment	Li et al. (2023); Li et al. (2019)
2	Ethical leadership	Well-being & Engagement; Organizational Commitment; Knowledge Sharing	Jia et al. (2022); Guo et al. (2022); Xia and Yang (2020)
3	Responsible leadership	Gratitude; Organizational Identification; Person-Organization Fit	Luo et al. (2025); Haider et al. (2022)
4	Supportive leadership	Innovative Behavior; Technology Adoption	Ahmed et al. (2022)
5	Relational leadership	TMT Voice Behavior; Innovation Performance	Wang et al. (2022)
6	Distributed leadership	Team Effectiveness (Performance & Viability)	Wu and Cormican (2020)
7	Benevolent/Paternalistic leadership	Team Creative Performance; Self-Efficacy	Xia et al. (2021)
8	Authentic leadership	Psychological Capital; Job Performance	Sarwar et al. (2022)
9	Value-based leadership	Intrinsic Work Motivation	Zhao et al. (2024)
10	Empowering leadership	Employee Innovation; Psychological Capital	Liu (2022)
11	Authoritarian leadership	Affective Conflict (Negative Outcome)	Cheah et al. (2022)
12	Bottom-Line Mentality (BLM) leadership	Relative Deprivation & Psychological Safety (Negative Outcomes)	Wan et al. (2021)

3.6. Research objectives and prominent factors

Based on the comprehensive analysis of the articles, this section synthesizes the main findings and relevant factors (Table 4) concerning leadership in Chinese higher education, structured around the research objectives. Studies highlight a diverse landscape of leadership styles within Chinese higher education institutions and their varied impacts on crucial outcomes. Positive leadership approaches, such as transformational (Li et al., 2023), ethical (Guo et al., 2022; Jia et al., 2022), responsible (Luo et al., 2025; Haider et al., 2022), supportive (Ahmed et al., 2022), relational (Wang et al., 2022), shared/distributed (Wu & Cormican, 2020), benevolent/moral (Cheah et al., 2022), authentic (Sarwar et al., 2022), value-based (Zhao et al., 2024), and empowering (Liu, 2022) leadership, are consistently linked to beneficial results. This leadership enhanced employee innovative behavior, improved well-being and work engagement, increased ethical work behavior, better knowledge sharing, higher organizational citizenship behavior, improved decision-making quality, stronger team effectiveness and creative performance, better job performance, increased intrinsic motivation, and greater intention to continue using technologies.

Conversely, the literature also illuminates the detrimental effects of negative leadership styles and workplace issues. A leader's bottom-line mentality (BLM) significantly inhibits teacher innovation by fostering relative deprivation and diminishing psychological safety (Wan et al., 2021). Similarly, authoritarian leadership, particularly during crises, can negatively impact decision quality by exacerbating affective conflict within teams (Cheah et al., 2022). Furthermore, deviant workplace behaviors, encompassing mistreatment, bullying, and incivility, are strongly correlated with increased employee turnover intentions (Qi et al., 2022). These negative dynamics exist alongside broader contextual challenges in Chinese higher education, including managing crises like the COVID-19 pandemic (Zhang & Tian, 2022), adapting to technological advancements (Ahmed et al., 2022), addressing gender inequality (Zhao & Jones, 2017), tackling rural-urban disparities (Fu & Zhu, 2022), and ensuring teacher well-being and motivation (Zhao et al., 2024).

Leadership plays the mediating mechanisms that influence outcomes. Psychological and cognitive variables play a significant role, including organizational trust, psychological capital, gratitude, organizational identification, prosocial motivation, creative self-efficacy, relative deprivation, and psychological safety (Zeng & Xu, 2019; Wan et al., 2021; Luo et al., 2025). Behavioral factors also act as crucial intermediaries, such as work engagement, innovative work behavior, and TMT voice behavior (Jia et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2022). Additionally, organizational and relational elements like organizational commitment (Guo et al., 2022), person-organization fit (Haider et al., 2022), and the nature of the intra-team conflict

(cognitive vs. affective) (Cheah et al., 2022) mediate the path from leadership input to employee and organizational outcomes.

Moreover, the effectiveness of leadership is not uniform but is contingent upon various boundary conditions. Organizational and cultural factors, such as the overall organizational culture, the fit between individual and organizational values, and perceived organizational support (POS) moderate leadership impacts (Haider et al., 2022; Sarwar et al., 2022; Wan et al., 2021). Interpersonal dynamics, particularly the Chinese concept of Guanxi (Zeng & Xu, 2019), also shape these relationships. At the team level, characteristics like the TMT's educational level and average age, as well as the specific stage of the project life cycle, influence leadership effectiveness (Wang et al., 2022; Wu & Cormican, 2020). Individual differences are also critical moderators, including perceived empowerment, conscientiousness facets like dutifulness and achievement-striving, growth mindset, and generational differences among academic staff (Li et al., 2019; Xia & Yang, 2020; Zhao et al., 2024). The interplay between leadership styles, such as how empowerment moderates the impact of transformational leadership on deviant behaviors, further highlights the complexity of leadership dynamics in this context (Qi et al., 2022).

4. Conclusion

Leadership in Chinese higher education is a complex and evolving research field. This review, based on 24 targeted articles published between 2016 and 2025, systematically analyzed key themes in leadership studies within Chinese higher education. The findings reveal a diverse landscape encompassing positive leadership styles (transformational, ethical, responsible, relational, shared, paternalistic, authentic, value-based, etc.) and negative forms like bottom-line mentality. These styles affect organizational and individual outcomes—such as innovation, well-being, engagement, OCB, knowledge sharing, technology use, team effectiveness, and ethical behavior—through complex mediating mechanisms involving psychological (trust, identification, psychological capital, safety) and behavioral (engagement, voice, innovation) factors. Leadership effectiveness is further moderated by organizational culture, interpersonal “guanxi,” team and individual traits (age, education, values, generation), and external contexts (crisis events, project life cycle). Methodologically, quantitative studies using SEM/PLS-SEM dominate, while qualitative research addresses specific contexts.

4.1. Theoretical and practical implications

These studies collectively underscore the critical role of leadership in the reform and development of Chinese higher education. The findings offer important practical implications. For university administrators, it is recommended to develop and promote positive leadership styles like ethical, transformational, responsible, supportive, and authentic leadership to stimulate faculty/staff proactivity, creativity, and commitment. Leaders also need to attend to employees' psychological states by building trust, enhancing psychological capital, and fostering psychological safety. For policymakers and leadership development programs, leadership practices must be tailored to specific contexts, recognizing that different cultural backgrounds, team characteristics, project phases, and generational differences may require adapted strategies. Strategies should also address real-world challenges, such as bridging rural-urban gaps, promoting gender equality, managing crises effectively, and driving technology integration.

4.2. Limitations

The limitations of this review stem from its analysis being based on the 24 provided articles, which prevents claims of comprehensiveness and limits the generalizability of conclusions. Additionally, the predominance of quantitative methods in the analyzed literature may introduce common method bias and might not sufficiently explore complex phenomena such as deep cultural influences or dynamic leadership evolution. A further limitation is the exclusion of Chinese-language studies and grey literature. While methodologically justifiable for consistency, this exclusion introduces a potential for language and publication bias, as significant insights from local scholarship may have been overlooked, thereby shaping the scope of the findings.

4.3. Future research directions

Future research could focus on examining leadership practices in different types of HEIs (e.g. vocational colleges, private universities), diverse disciplines, and wider geographical regions within China. To diversify the understanding of leadership across fields, future studies could expand disciplinary coverage into areas such as STEM, arts, or vocational education. Furthermore, future work should address topics such as leadership in digital transformation, university leaders' responsibility under sustainable development goals, cross-cultural leadership comparisons, and the long-term impacts of negative leadership.

Author contribution statement

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Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author, upon reasonable request.

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